IT

Writing a Technical IT Incident Report

A Scaffolded Writing Task · CEFR B1+

Inglés Profesional · ASIR / DAW · Networking & IT Vocabulary

1 What Is an Incident Report?

An incident report is a short, formal text that explains a problem, what was done about it, and what happened as a result. IT technicians write incident reports so that managers, colleagues and future technicians understand what went wrong and how it was fixed.

1

Clear

Anyone can understand what happened, step by step.

2

Logical order

Introduction → Actions → Result → Recommendation.

3

Formal style

Neutral tone, passive voice, no contractions.

2 The Structure of a Report

1. Introduction

When the problem happened, who reported it, and what it was.

"On Friday, a network problem was reported by the sales department."

2. Actions Taken

What the technician did, step by step, to find and fix it.

"First, he checked the firewall. Then he ran a diagnostic test."

3. Result

What happened after the actions were taken.

"As a result, the terminals could authenticate again."

4. Recommendation

A suggestion to prevent the same problem again.

"It is recommended that the team carry out a full audit."

3 Language Toolbox — Tone & Style

- ✓ Use a neutral, formal tone — this is not an email to a friend.
- ✓ Prefer the passive voice when the person who acted is not important: “The router was restarted.”
- ✓ Avoid contractions: write do not, could not, did not — never don't, couldn't, didn't.
- ✓ Use the past simple for the main events, and the past perfect for something earlier: “He found the server had run out of addresses.”
- ✓ For recommendations use It is recommended that… + base form, or the simpler You should…

4 Linking Words — Putting Events in Order

First / To begin with
sequencing

First, the technician checked the cables.

Then / After that
sequencing

Then, she restarted the router.

Once / After
sequencing

Once the update was installed, it rebooted.

As a result
cause/effect

As a result, the connection was restored.

However
contrast

However, the problem happened again.

Finally
closing point

Finally, it is recommended that backups run daily.

5 Key Technical Nouns (1/2)

server *noun*

a computer that provides data/services: The main server stopped responding.

network *noun*

a group of connected devices: All devices on the network lost connection.

database *noun*

an organised set of digital data: The database could not be accessed.

firewall *noun*

blocks unwanted network traffic: The firewall blocked the connection.

malware / virus *noun*

harmful software: A virus was detected on the shared computer.

backup *noun*

a saved copy of data: The server was restored from the latest backup.

5 Key Technical Nouns (2/2)

outage / downtime
noun

a period a system is not working: The outage lasted two hours.

bandwidth
noun

data a network can carry: Low bandwidth slowed the connection.

IP address
noun

a number identifying a device: The device got a new IP address.

patch / update
noun

a small software fix: A security patch was installed.

breach
noun

a security incident: IT is investigating the security breach.

credentials
noun

username + password: Her credentials no longer worked.

6 Verb & Phrasal Verb Bank (1/2)

run into *insep.*

to have an unexpected problem: We ran into a compatibility issue.

crash / freeze up *insep.*

to fail suddenly: The server crashed during peak hours.

go down *insep.*

to stop working: The system went down at 9 a.m.

troubleshoot —

to look for and solve a problem: She troubleshot the connection.

look into *insep.*

to investigate: IT is looking into the breach.

configure —

to set up correctly: He configured the firewall before going live.

6 Verb & Phrasal Verb Bank (2/2)

log in / on *insep.*
to start a session: He couldn't log in without the password.

authenticate —
to verify identity: The user was authenticated with 2FA.

roll back *sep.*
to return to a previous version: They rolled back the update.

carry out *sep.*
to perform / execute: The team carried out a full scan.

back up *sep.*
to copy data: Remember to back up the database.

deploy —
to put a change into use: The fix was deployed overnight.

7 Sentence Frames — Introduction & Actions Taken

Introduction

- On [day/date], a problem was reported / detected in the ___.
- The issue was that ___ could not ___.
- This meant that ___.

Actions Taken

- A technician was asked to troubleshoot / investigate the problem.
- First, ___ was checked / configured / restarted.
- Then, ___ was carried out to find out what was happening.
- After a few minutes, it was found that ___.

7 Sentence Frames — Result & Recommendation

Result

- As a result, ___.
- Once this had been done, ___ was able to ___ again.

Recommendation

- It is recommended that ___ in order to prevent this from happening again.
- The IT team suggests that ___.
- You should ___ to avoid this in the future.

8 Model Report (Annotated)

Last week, the main server stopped responding after a scheduled update. Staff could not access shared files or the student database.	*Passive voice + technical nouns: server, database.*
A network technician was asked to investigate. First, he checked the server logs. Then he restarted the server, but it crashed again a few minutes later.	*Linking words: First… Then… Vocabulary: investigate, crashed.*
As a result, he restored the server from the latest backup, and all services were working normally again within an hour.	*"As a result" = cause → effect. Technical noun: backup.*
It is recommended that all updates be tested on a backup server before being installed on the main system.	*Formal recommendation frame.*

9 Planning Grid — Before You Write

Make quick notes (not full sentences) in each box before you start writing.

Problem

Actions Taken

Result

Recommendation

10 Your Turn — Write Your Report

Choose ONE option (or use your own notes from Computer Activity A: Diagnostics Lab). Write 80–120 words.

A The Wi-Fi network in your school went down for two hours during a lesson.

B A virus was detected on a computer in the IT lab and started to spread to other computers on the network.

C Use your own diagnostics notes from Computer Activity A.

Remember: Title → Introduction → Actions Taken → Result → Recommendation

11 Self- / Peer-Review Checklist

- [ ] My report has four parts: Introduction, Actions Taken, Result, Recommendation.
- [ ] I used at least four verbs or phrasal verbs from the language toolbox.
- [ ] I used at least two technical IT nouns (server, network, database, backup...).
- [ ] I used the passive voice at least twice.
- [ ] I used at least two linking words (First, Then, As a result...).
- [ ] I did not use contractions (don't, can't, didn't...).
- [ ] My report is between 80 and 120 words.

MODEL ANSWER · Option B (virus in the IT lab)

On Wednesday morning, a virus was detected on a computer in the IT lab. The antivirus software sent an alert, and it was found that the virus had already started to spread to two other computers on the network.

The IT technician disconnected the infected computers from the network immediately to stop the virus from spreading further. Then he ran a full antivirus scan on all three machines and removed the infected files.

As a result, the network was declared safe again after two hours, and normal classes were able to continue the next day.

It is recommended that all computers run automatic virus scans every week in order to detect problems like this sooner.

~105 words · 4 parts · passive voice · linking words · technical vocabulary